

THE RESURRECTION TRUTH OR CONSEQUENCES?

(Easter 2022)

TEXT: 1 Corinthians 15:12-19 (KJV) *“Now if Christ is preached that He has been raised from the dead, how do some among you say that there is no resurrection of the dead? ¹³ But if there is no resurrection of the dead, then Christ is not risen. ¹⁴ And if Christ is not risen, then our preaching is empty and your faith is also empty. ¹⁵ Yes, and we are found false witnesses of God, because we have testified of God that He raised up Christ, whom He did not raise up—if in fact the dead do not rise. ¹⁶ For if the dead do not rise, then Christ is not risen. ¹⁷ And if Christ is not risen, your faith is futile; you are still in your sins! ¹⁸ Then also those who have fallen asleep in Christ have perished. ¹⁹ If in this life only we have hope in Christ, we are of all men the most pitiable.”*

INTRO: I like to refer to those of us who are Christ followers as “*Easter People.*” The Bible says “*If Christ be not raised our faith is in vain and we are yet in our sins.*” As Easter people, it is our duty to make Christ's kingdom known in His world.

Questioning the resurrection is not a twenty-first-century phenomenon. Beginning in the first century, there were those who questioned the resurrection. Vs. 12 “*Now if Christ is preached that He has been raised from the dead, how do some among you say that there is no resurrection of the dead?*”

Why would anyone not believe in the resurrection? The truth is, the Easter story is full of misunderstanding:

- Mary thought Jesus' body had been stolen...
- Peter saw the linen wrappings and couldn't figure out what it was all about...
- The disciples obviously missed the message of the death, burial and resurrection...

- The angels questioned Mary, and she still didn't know what was going on, she thought Jesus was the gardener...

One could hardly get more misunderstanding into a couple of paragraphs, if one were trying to do so.

THE RESURRECTION OF JESUS AND THE RESURRECTION OF THE DEAD ARE INEXTRICABLY CONNECTED...

Vs. 13 ***“If there is no resurrection of the dead, then Christ is not risen.”***

The truth is, Easter has always been a bit confusing... The truth of the resurrection entered:

- The world of space... Real history!
- The world of time... Real people!
- The world of matter... Real life!

The confusion of the resurrection stems from the fact that our minds and imaginations are too

small to contain it. So, we do our best to put the sea into a bottle, and fit the explosive fact of the resurrection into the possibilities we already know about.

At some level, the misunderstanding of the disciples, and our misunderstandings, is a mark of the story's authenticity. You can't make this stuff up!

The consequences of no resurrection are devastating to the human condition. If He was in fact not raised, there is no hope of resurrection for succeeding generations! Can we survive without the hope of resurrection day to day? Can we survive without the hope of eternal resurrection?

The truth of the matter is “*He is risen*” and so are we!

**OUR ENTIRE SYSTEM OF FAITH IS
PREDECATED ON THE RESURRECTION
OF JESUS FROM THE DEAD...**

Vs. 14-15 ***“If Christ is not risen, then our preaching is empty and your faith is also empty. ¹⁵ Yes, and we are found false witnesses of God, because we have testified of God that He raised up Christ, whom He did not raise up—if in fact the dead do not rise.”***

The fact is, our theology is totally dependent on what happened in that cemetery more than 2,000 years ago! It is also true, that from that time until now, the resurrection is a little difficult for human beings to process.

Just think of all the cascading events the people experiencing the first resurrection were having to process, in real time:

- The denial of Jesus by Simon Peter...
- The absence of the remainder of the disciples around the cross...
- A dead savior hanging on a cross...
- A borrowed tomb, because no one anticipated this outcome...

- A sealed tomb, to keep the scandal of a resurrection from occurring...
- A predawn cemetery surprise that would shock the world to its foundations...
- A napkin folded and strategically placed to indicate something very different happening in a sealed tomb...
- The Emmaus encounter that indicated the level of shock on the part of those who knew the savior best...
- The Thomas notification that seemed to signal the beginning of a dispensation filled with grace...
- The resurrected Christ defying the laws of physics by walking through walls...

The characters in the story of this first resurrection were obviously ill-prepared to process what they were witnessing, and to some degree, those of us who are reading it more than 2,000 years later, are still struggling to wrap our minds around the truth of the resurrection.

The consequences of a no resurrection world is that:

- Our preaching is empty...
- Our faith is in vain...
- We are false witnesses...

THE RESURRECTION INITIATES THE BELIEF IN THE FORGIVENESS OF SIN AND LIFE BEYOND THE GRAVE

Vs. 17-18 *“And if Christ is not risen, your faith is futile; you are still in your sins! ¹⁸ Then also those who have fallen asleep in Christ have perished.”*

A leading agnostic scholar described the struggle the first-century and twenty-first-century earthlings wrestle with, concerning the resurrection: *“It looks as though they were struggling to describe something for which they didn't have adequate language.”*

From the time of the first resurrection, until now, people have tried to compress the Easter message into conventional boxes in which it just won't fit.

Easter is what it is, because together with Jesus' crucifixion, it is the central event of world history—the moment towards which everything was rushing and from which everything emerges new.

The death and resurrection of Jesus of Nazareth, initiated a shock wave that has rattled through the world, so that despite appearances, this message is an absolute fact.

The resurrection of Jesus from the dead allows us to believe:

- Our sins are gone...
- The dead are alive...

The consequences of a non-resurrection theology, is that we are hopelessly enslaved to our sins - AND the dead are permanently dead!

Praise God, our sins are gone and the dead are alive!

CONCLUSION:

Easter is about:

- Real life, not foggy history...
- Present efficacy, not escapist fantasy...
- God's mercy, not jurisdictional judgment...
- Personal freedom, not subjective culpability...

Easter is about God's rich welcome to all of creation to live in a space marked by personal peace and freedom. As Easter people we are called to celebrate all of this in practical ways of kingdom building.

Make no mistake about it, the resurrection in that particular cemetery, so many years ago, is continuing to have an ongoing effect today:

- Easter is about Jesus...
- Easter is about His virgin birth...
- Easter is about His sinless life...
- Easter is about the Jesus who announced God's saving, sovereign kingdom...
- Easter is about the Jesus who died to exhaust the power of this world's rulers...
- Easter is about the Jesus who rose again to be crowned as king, over all things in heaven, and on earth...
- Easter I about bringing Heaven to Earth through Easter people...
- Easter is about His soon return...

All these things are inextricably connected to one outcome, “*He is risen,*” and so are we!

And, if there is no resurrection the consequences are – “*...we are yet in our sin, and our faith is in vain!*”